Book One

From my grandfather Verus I learned good morals and the government of my temper.

From the reputation and remembrance of my father, modesty and a manly character.

From my mother, piety and beneficence, and abstinence, not only from evil deeds, but even from evil thoughts; and further, simplicity in my way of living, far removed from the habits of the rich.

Book Two

Begin the morning by saying to thyself, I shall meet with the busy-body, the ungrateful, arrogant, deceitful, envious, unsocial.

Do not act as if thou wert going to live ten thousand years. Death hangs over thee. While thou livest, while it is in thy power, be good.

Book Three

Men seek retreats for themselves, houses in the country, sea-shores, and mountains. But it is in thy power whenever thou shalt choose to retire into thyself.

Waste no more time arguing about what a good man should be. Be one.

Book Four

Very little is needed to make a happy life; it is all within thyself, in thy way of thinking.

Look within. Within is the fountain of good, and it will ever bubble up, if thou wilt ever dig.